
World Health Organization (WHO) – Public Health Alert

Epidemiological Situation in Australia

Event ID: **WHO-WPRO-Resp-2024-002**

Affected Region: **Australia (Queensland)**

Notified by: **Australian National IHR Focal Point**

17 October 2024

Urgent Update: Identification of Novel Virus in Australia : The Australian Government Department of Health and Aged Care, in collaboration with Queensland Health, has notified WHO of the identification of a novel virus (provisionally named "Virus X") associated with severe respiratory infections in Queensland. The virus was detected through meta-sequencing of clinical specimens by the Doherty Institute and has been made publicly available on GenBank as of October 17, 2024.

Preliminary genomic analysis suggests that Virus X is a previously uncharacterized respiratory virus, with potential for severe illness in vulnerable populations. The pathogenicity, transmissibility, and zoonotic origins of the virus remain under investigation.

Key Developments (October 9–16, 2024)

- 38 total confirmed hospitalizations for acute respiratory illness across multiple hospitals in Brisbane and Townsville.
- 4 confirmed deaths linked to the Kelvin Grove nursing home outbreak.
- Multiple cases tested negative for known respiratory pathogens before Virus X identification.
- 1 confirmed hospitalization in Townsville with travel history from Brisbane. Contact tracing ongoing.

At present, no international cases have been reported, but WHO urges enhanced global surveillance given the emergence of this novel pathogen.

Risk Assessment (WHO Internal Advisory)

- **Public Health Risk: High** (due to novel pathogen status and increasing case numbers).
- **Potential for Global Spread: Moderate** (no international cases yet, but ongoing investigation).
- **Severity: Severe** cases observed in elderly and young children, but full clinical spectrum unknown.
- **Zoonotic or Human-to-Human Transmission: Under investigation**; currently no evidence of sustained human-to-human spread.

WHO does not yet classify this as a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC) but will continue to assess the situation.

WHO Recommended Public Health Actions

- All Member States should enhance surveillance for severe acute respiratory infections (SARI) and report any unexplained pneumonia clusters to WHO under IHR (2005).
- Laboratories worldwide are urged to sequence clinical specimens from patients with severe respiratory illness and compare with Virus X sequence available on GenBank.
- Clinicians should remain alert for patients presenting with severe pneumonia or atypical respiratory symptoms, particularly in individuals with recent travel to Queensland, Australia.
- Governments should review pandemic preparedness plans in case of increased spread.
- No travel or trade restrictions are recommended at this time, but WHO advises travelers from affected areas to self-monitor for symptoms.

Next Steps & International Coordination

- **WHO Western Pacific Regional Office (WPRO)** is in direct communication with Australian health authorities to monitor the situation.
- A technical consultation with international virology and epidemiology experts is scheduled in the coming days.
- Further updates will be issued as new data on Virus X becomes available.